

Document 24B. Evaluation Mastery Guide — CSQ + Essay, SPECIES+A, Mark-Scheme Aligned

Purpose. Doc 24 introduced the evaluation toolkit. This document goes deeper: it extends evaluation technique to Paper 2 essays (15–25 marks), upgrades the SPECIES framework into **SPECIES+A** by adding *Assumptions* / *model challenges*, and gives you a stem-to-criterion decision matrix so you stop guessing which evaluation move to deploy.

Core principle. Evaluation is not a section at the end of your answer — it is a *habit of thought* applied to every claim. The grade boundary between B and A is the candidate who automatically asks “*magnitude, time-horizon, who bears the cost, and what assumption am I making?*” as they write each sentence.

Section A. Where Evaluation Lives — CSQ vs Essay

Component	Paper 1 CSQ (8m, 10m)	Paper 2 Essay (15m discuss, 10m explain, 25m total)
KAA bands	L1 / L2 (two-level grid)	L1 / L2 / L3 (three-level grid for 15m discuss part)
Evaluation bands	E1 / E2 (two-level)	E1 / E2 / E3 (three-level for 25-mark essays)
Evaluation weight	2–3 of 8–10 marks (25–30%)	5–7 of 25 marks (20–28%)
Required moves	Two-sided + SPECIES + judgement	Two-sided thesis/antithesis <i>plus</i> reasoned weighting of frameworks <i>plus</i> explicit synthesis stance
Evidence anchor	Extract data (mandatory)	Singapore policy examples + real-world data + theoretical caveats

NOTE: The biggest mistake transitioning from CSQ to Essay evaluation: students drop the extract-anchor habit and produce abstract evaluation. Essay evaluation must still anchor in specific evidence — the difference is that you supply the evidence yourself (Singapore policy data, year-tagged), since there is no extract.

Section B. SEAB Mark-Scheme Language (Extended)

Paper 1 CSQ (8m, 10m “Discuss”).

Band	Descriptor
L2	Well-balanced two-sided answer, scope and rigour, case-evidence anchored, accurate diagrams.
L1	Descriptive / mostly irrelevant / one-sided / conceptual errors.
E2	Judgement explained AND substantiated — includes magnitude / elasticity / time-horizon / stakeholder qualifier.
E1	Unexplained stand or restatement of earlier points.
E0	No evaluation — caps the answer at L1/L2 KAA.

Paper 2 Essay — 15-mark “Discuss” / 25-mark question.

Band	Descriptor
L3 (12–15)	Comprehensive scope, rigorous analysis using accurate frameworks (AD/AS, market structure, BOP, etc.), multiple developed thesis and antithesis points, sophisticated application to context.
L2 (8–11)	Good two-sided answer; some development; mostly correct frameworks; some application.
L1 (1–7)	Descriptive; one-sided; conceptual errors; little/no application.
E3 (8–10)	Substantiated stance going beyond summary; synthesis across thesis/antithesis; assumption-challenge or higher-order qualifier (PED, MPC, time, Marshall–Lerner); explicit conditions for the conclusion.
E2 (5–7)	Stand substantiated by economic reasoning, but partial; misses one of: magnitude / time / alternative / assumption.
E1 (1–4)	Stand without reasoning, restatement, or vague “it depends.”

E2 → E3 (the A-grade move). Beyond magnitude and time, an E3 candidate *challenges a model assumption*: “the multiplier analysis assumes no crowding out; in Singapore’s open economy, leakages and capital mobility may reduce k below 0.7...” This is the move the original SPECIES misses. SPECIES+A makes it explicit.

Section C. SPECIES+A — The Upgraded Framework

Original 7 (Hyco): Short/Long-run · Priorities · Extent · Cost · Impact on stakeholders · Efficacy of alternatives · Side-effects.

Added 8th: Assumptions / model challenges — the only move that consistently distinguishes E2 from E3.

	Criterion	Sentence template	When essential
S	Short-run vs long-run	“In SR, [claim] holds because [reason]. In LR, [opposite] because [adjustment].”	Every policy question
P	Priorities of government	“Effectiveness depends on whether priority is [X] or [Y].”	Multi-aim conflicts
E	Extent of problem	“If [problem] is severe, [thesis]; if mild, [antithesis].”	“How severe / how much?”
C	Cost (fiscal / opportunity)	“\$X used here could fund [alternative] yielding [welfare].”	Spending policies
I	Impact on stakeholders	“Group A gains [type], Group B loses [type]. Net effect depends on...”	Distributional questions
E	Efficacy of alternatives	“Alternative [policy] yields [outcome] because [reason], but limited by...”	“Best / most effective”
S	Side-effects	“[Policy] may create [unintended consequence], reducing net welfare.”	Almost always
A	Assumptions (new)	“This argument assumes [X]. In Singapore’s context, [X] may not hold because [Y], meaning [implication].”	E3 / A-grade move

Assumption-challenge bank — memorise 5 of these.

- Multiplier** assumes no crowding out + closed economy. In Singapore: high import leakage + high CPF MPS, so $k \approx 0.5\text{--}0.7$, not the $1.5\text{--}2.5$ typical of larger closed economies.
- Marshall–Lerner** assumes $|PED_X| + |PED_M| > 1$ for depreciation to improve CA. May not hold short-run $\Rightarrow$ J-curve.
- Pigouvian tax** assumes government can measure MEC accurately. In practice MEC is uncertain and politically contested.
- Ceteris paribus** in DD/SS analysis. Real-world shocks rarely change one variable at a time.

5. **Rational consumers** in info-failure questions. Behavioural anomalies (hyperbolic discounting, anchoring, social conformity) explain why even subsidies under-perform.
6. **Perfect mobility of factors** in trade theory. Structural unemployment from trade liberalisation is precisely the violation of this assumption.
7. **Liquidity-preference** channel for monetary policy. Singapore does not use r as a tool $\Rightarrow$ this entire channel is irrelevant; transmission is via S\$NEER.

Section D. Stem-to-SPECIES+A Decision Matrix

Use this to pre-select your 2–3 strongest evaluation moves before you write.

Stem	Default SPECIES+A picks (in priority order)
“Discuss whether [X is true]”	E (extent), S (SR/LR), A (assumption)
“Assess the effectiveness of [policy]”	S (SR/LR), C (cost), S (side-effects), A
“To what extent...”	E (extent / magnitude), A (assumption limiting extent)
“Evaluate whether [X] is the best”	E (efficacy of alternatives), C, I
“Discuss consequences of...”	I (stakeholders), S (side-effects), E (extent)
“Discuss whether [country] should...”	P (priorities), I, A (assumption about country)
“Compare [policy A] and [policy B]”	E (alternatives), S (SR/LR for each), I
“Justify [tariff/quota/intervention]”	S (side-effects), E (alternatives), C (welfare cost)
“Discuss whether consumers benefit”	I (allocative/dynamic), S (SR/LR), A (contestability assumption)

Section E. Paper 2 Essay Evaluation Architecture (NEW vs Hyco Guide)

The original guide is CSQ-only. Paper 2 essays demand a different evaluation architecture because there is no extract, more time, and a higher mark ceiling. Use the structure below for any 15-mark or 25-mark essay part.

The 4-Layer Essay Evaluation Stack.

Layer 1 — Embedded mini-evaluation (within each thesis/antithesis paragraph).

After your causal chain and example, end the paragraph with: “*However, this argument is limited by [SPECIES+A move].*” This shows evaluation woven throughout, not bolted on.

Layer 2 — Dedicated evaluation paragraph (after thesis + antithesis).

Open with “*In evaluating these competing claims...*” then deploy 2–3 SPECIES+A criteria. This is the explicit weighing.

Layer 3 — Assumption challenge (the E3 lever).

Open with “*Both sides of the argument rest on [shared assumption]. If [assumption fails], then...*” This is the move that elevates an essay from L3/E2 to L3/E3.

Layer 4 — Synthesis conclusion with binding condition.

Open with “*On balance, [stance] because [dominant SPECIES+A criterion], conditional on [binding context].*” Avoid “in conclusion” (filler) and “it depends” (E1 floor).

Worked Layer-3 example (assumption challenge).

“*Both the thesis (fiscal expansion raises Y via multiplier) and antithesis (crowding out limits the effect) rest on the assumption that the central bank holds interest rates constant. In Singapore’s case this assumption is moot — MAS targets the S\$NEER, not the interest rate, so r is endogenous to global capital flows. The relevant trade-off is therefore not fiscal vs monetary crowding out, but fiscal vs imported-inflation crowding out via S\$ depreciation pressure. This reframes the question entirely.*”

Section F. Essay Evaluation by 15-mark vs 25-mark Architecture

Question type	Time & structure	Evaluation expectations
10-mark (a)-part	18 min; AO1+AO2 only	No formal evaluation needed; but include one magnitude / time qualifier to lift to top band of explanation.
15-mark (b)-part	27 min; thesis + antithesis + judgement	2–3 SPECIES+A criteria; explicit stance; one assumption challenge for L3/E2.
25-mark essay (full)	45 min; combines (a) + (b) format	Full 4-layer stack from Section E; 3–4 SPECIES+A criteria; synthesis with binding condition; cite Singapore policy + year.

Section G. Sentence-Starter Bank — Extended for Essay Use

Opening an evaluation paragraph (Essay style):

- “In weighing these arguments, the decisive consideration is...”
- “The strength of the thesis depends critically on...”
- “A more nuanced view emerges when we recognise that...”

Assumption challenge (the E3 move):

- “This conclusion rests on the assumption that... a condition unlikely to hold in [context] because...”
- “The standard model abstracts from [feature]; once we re-introduce [feature], the welfare conclusion reverses because...”
- “The Marshall–Lerner / Keynesian-multiplier / Pigouvian framework implicitly assumes...”

Synthesis stance (closing):

- “On balance, [stance], primarily because [dominant SPECIES+A criterion]. This conclusion holds firmly when [binding condition] obtains, and would require revision if [counter-condition].”
- “The weight of evidence favours [stance] not because [alternative] is wrong, but because [alternative] is dominated by [SPECIES+A criterion] in the specific context of [economy/sector/period].”

Section H. Self-Mark Rubric (Use After Every Practice Essay)

Score yourself 0–3 on each criterion. Target: $\geq 18 / 24$ for an A-grade trajectory.

#	Criterion	Max	Your score
1	Did you write a clear thesis with 2–3 developed points?	3	
2	Did you write a clear antithesis directly challenging the thesis?	3	
3	Did every point have a causal chain (mechanism), not just an assertion?	3	
4	Did you cite extract evidence (CSQ) or Singapore-specific evidence (essay)?	3	
5	Did you deploy at least 2 SPECIES+A criteria with full sentence-templates?	3	
6	Did you challenge at least 1 model assumption explicitly (the E3 lever)?	3	
7	Did your conclusion take an explicit stance with a binding condition?	3	
8	Diagrams: fully labelled (axes, curves, equilibria, shaded areas)?	3	
Total (target $\geq 18/24$ for A-grade trajectory)		24	

Section I. Common Evaluation Failures — A Diagnostic Catalogue

Failure mode	Why it fails	Fix
“It depends” alone	E1 cap. No substantiation.	Always pair with “on [specific factor X], which determines the outcome because...”
Listing all 7 (8) SPECIES	Shallow, rushed.	Pick 2–3 most relevant from the stem-to-SPECIES matrix (Section D).
Antithesis is a different topic	You are listing, not weighing.	Antithesis must directly challenge the thesis on the same proposition.
Conclusion = summary of earlier points	E1 at best.	Synthesis: stake out a position and explain <i>why</i> it is more convincing.
Evaluation only at the end	Loses time-allocation and embeds nothing.	Embed mini-eval per paragraph (Layer 1) <i>plus</i> a dedicated evaluation paragraph (Layers 2–3).
No assumption challenge	Capped at E2 even with strong KAA.	Apply at least one A move (Section C). This is the E2→E3 lever.
Singapore example missing in essay	Loses application AO2 marks.	At least one Singapore policy with year (e.g. “MAS appreciation, Apr 2022”).
Quoting extract without analysis	Citation unlinked.	After every quote: “ <i>indicating that...</i> ” to extract economic meaning.

Section J. Worked Example — A-Grade Essay Evaluation Paragraph

Question: “Discuss whether MAS’s exchange-rate-centred monetary policy is more effective than fiscal policy in managing inflation in Singapore.” [15]

Layer 2 + Layer 3 evaluation paragraph (showcased):

In weighing the two approaches, the decisive consideration is the source of inflation, which determines which policy lever is appropriate (Extent of problem, SPECIES E). For imported cost-push inflation — the dominant inflation source in Singapore since 2022 — MAS appreciation reduces import prices directly via the high pass-through coefficient (estimated ~ 0.4 for headline CPI), whereas fiscal contraction would compound the output loss that already accompanies a cost-push shock (Side-effect, S). However, both arguments share a common assumption that the appreciation does not damage export competitiveness disproportionately (Assumptions, A). If exports become uncompetitive in the long run — a particular risk when trading partners simultaneously depreciate — the inflation gain is purchased at the cost of structural unemployment in manufacturing, which fiscal policy cannot easily reverse. In short, the relative effectiveness of MAS over fiscal is conditional on (i) the inflation being externally-imported rather than domestic-demand-pull, and (ii) trading partners not engaging in competitive depreciation.

Layer 4 synthesis conclusion:

On balance, MAS exchange-rate policy is more effective than fiscal policy in managing Singapore’s inflation, primarily because the openness of the economy (trade-to-GDP $> 300\%$) amplifies the exchange-rate channel while suppressing the fiscal multiplier ($k \approx 0.5\text{--}0.7$). This conclusion holds firmly for the 2022–23 imported-inflation episode where MAS executed five consecutive tightening moves with measurable CPI moderation. The conclusion would require revision if the inflation source were domestic demand-pull at full employment, in which case targeted fiscal restraint — combined with supply-side investment to ease capacity constraints — would dominate.

Final principle. An A-grade evaluator does not write longer answers. They write *tighter* answers in which every paragraph carries an evaluative load. Master the SPECIES+A vocabulary until each criterion takes you 20 seconds to deploy. That fluency is the actual exam skill.